While I was there, I also bumped into the legendary Bob Woolmer. I would stay connected with Bob over that year and beyond. I remember he told me that he'd been following my career for a while and was surprised that I had been dropped from the team. Eventually, he was appointed coach of the Pakistan team – Javed Miandad got the boot after the home series against India, though Inzi bhai retained his captaincy – and I had an easy route back in, because Bob had seen me in action in South Africa and was gunning for me. We had bonded well there.

I was lucky but also aggressive about my goals. I'd known that performing well in South Africa, home to some of the fastest pitches in the world at the time, was key to making a comeback. I didn't go down the political route – *parchi*, as we call it – which a lot of other players take recourse to by getting a powerful political or administrative patron to push for them to be included in the team roster, sometimes for favours returned, sometimes for endorsements. Instead, I did what I'm good at. I hit the ball around everywhere I could over those twelve months. I knew I'd be called back to the team. In hindsight, that comeback was easy.

Here's the thing: I like comebacks. Particularly in terms of what it does for you as a player, psychologically. Comebacks give you an objective, a point to prove, a target to hit. Aimless wandering isn't my thing. So, in a way, being dropped worked in my favour. I headed to other leagues – the SA league, or county cricket in the UK, or Australia whenever things went south in terms of form or performance. Then, on being given a chance to return, I'd do so with a bang, the same way I'd made my debut.

But I never let the pressure of being out of the loop affect my game or my approach to it. My comeback journey wasn't about getting runs on the board to make a place for myself in the team. It was about scoring runs and scoring them my way. Coaches tried to change my game; they failed. Eventually, it was Bob Woolmer who got it right. But in those early years, I was nervous about getting skinned by Miandad or the likes over a bad innings played my way. Honestly, I didn't care if I was or wasn't doing well, as long as I was doing things my way.

Anyway, after taking on India in 2004 at home, I was dropped again for the Asia Cup in Sri Lanka but picked for the tri-series against India and Australia in Holland (where I helped beat India), followed by the Champions Trophy, where I helped beat India again in the death overs with a cameo of 25. In those days, beating India was becoming fun again. While they had defeated us in the 2003 World Cup – I will never forget that blazing innings by Tendulkar at Centurion – maintaining their perfect 4-off-4 record against us in WC matches, Pakistan at the time still had a superior non-World Cup ODI win ratio by 2:1 over India.

Come 2005 and it was again time for the tour of tours for me – India. This would be Pakistan's first full outing to India in six years. The political context was different this time. After India's tour of Pakistan a year earlier, reciprocity was expected – both in terms of competitiveness and hospitality. Thankfully, the mood was peaceful. Our fans were allowed visas. People of both countries – and even the United Nations (UN) – appreciated the fact that Pakistan and India were using cricket as a confidence-building measure to normalize ties.

As for me, I was thankful for being back in the side: older and wiser than I'd been on my first visit to India. But I wasn't ready for what was about to happen on the ground. This time the political atmosphere was super-charged as my favourite leader at the time, President Musharraf, was also visiting the country. Personally, the tour was important for me as I'd just returned to the Test team. I was rested for the first Test in Delhi but I played the next two matches. In the second